at the speed with which they should have been. New tracks, locomotives and coaches incorporate safety in their very design.

Many experts also argue that India's track record of rail accidents is better than most countries, given the vast size of its network that makes it one of the largest in the world. There are over 107,832 km of running tracks on around 68,000-plus route km. In the past year, 5,200 km of new tracks were laid, equivalent to the entire rail network of Switzerland. The Indian Railways now runs 13,169 passenger trains a day and transported over 5 billion passengers last year, or four times the country's total population. It also runs 8,637 freight trains daily. V.N. Mathur, former member (traffic), Railway Board, defends the track record: "We must give credit that the number of rail accidents has come down drastically in the past two decades. Accidents per million train km, which is an international parameter, has come down in India from 0.65 in 2001 to 0.03 in 2022."

Manpower and maintenance remain the weak links in railway operations. Loco pilots often put in **shifts of more than 12 hours**, resulting in potential safety hazards

Yet, the Balasore accident—the worst railway mishap since 1995—revives crucial concerns about safety and other systemic challenges before the Indian Railways at a time when it is modernising and expanding to include faster, more comfortable trains. A December 2022 report by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) highlighted that the railways fell far short of the safety benchmarks in its own internal protocols. Its audit of railway accidents in the past four years showed that 69 per cent were caused by train derailments followed by track renewal and mechanical failure. It red-flagged issues such as track defects, engineering and maintenance issues and operating errors as some of the primary causes of derailments.

The CAG report also said that the amount spent on rail safety and track renewal was inadequate. Of the Rs 1 lakh crore set aside for five years starting 2017-2018 under the rail safety fund called the Rashtriya Rail Sanraksha Kosh, a third remained unutilised at the end of five years. Countering this, the rail ministry on June 5 claimed that the audit report did not capture the total spending between 2017-18 and 2021-22. In this period, the expenditure on safety-related works, which include track renewal, bridges, level crossings, railway over- and underbridges and signalling works, increased from Rs 70,274 crore between 2004-05 and 2013-14 to Rs 1.78 lakh crore between 2014-15 and 2023-24, an increase of two and a half times.



LOOKING AHEAD
A Vande Bharat Express train

ANI

GAUGING THE RAILWAYS

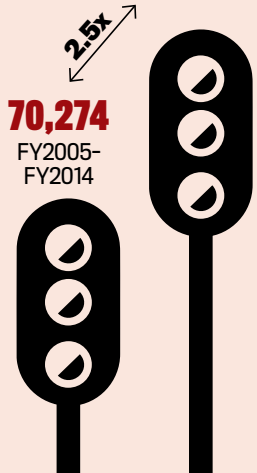
EXPENDITURE ON SAFETY-RELATED WORKS

The national transporter has spent over Rs 1.7 lakh crore in the past nine years to enhance safety on its ever-expanding network

(Figures in Rs crore) **1,78,012** FY2015-FY2024

2.5x

70,274 FY2005-FY2014



EXPENDITURE ON TRACK RENEWALS

The Rs 1.09 lakh crore spend on it made track renewal a major chunk of safety-related works

(Figures in Rs crore) **1,09,023** FY2015-FY2024

2.3x

47,039 FY2005-FY2014

